



UNIT II

Turning the Light On

The Progressive Era · 1890–1920

US.08

US.09

US.10

US.11

US.12

US.13

US.14

US.15

US.16

US.17

US.18

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

When a booming country leaves millions behind, who decides to fix it — and how? Progressive-era Americans fought over whether the answer was charity, protest, journalism, unions, or the government itself. Which of them actually moved the country?

By 1900 the American machine was running full tilt — and grinding people up in the gears. Kids worked instead of going to school. A few men owned whole industries. Factories caught fire with the doors locked. This unit is about the people who refused to call that 'just how it is' — the farmers and workers who organized, the journalists who dragged the ugliness into daylight, the reformers and presidents who wrote new rules, and the women who marched for twenty years to win the vote. You'll travel with friends you already know — Rosa, Frankie, and Anna — plus a Fisk student named Ada and a Tennessee teenager named May who ends up standing exactly where American history turns. Your job isn't to memorize the reforms. It's to decide which kind of power — a strike, a newspaper, a law, a vote — actually changed things, and why.

How this unit works

- Taught through story — you meet a worker, a farmer, a student before you meet a policy, so it sticks.
- Multiple perspectives — labor and owners, Washington and Du Bois, suffragist and skeptic, each represented fairly.
- Primary sources — Tarbell, Sinclair, Du Bois, the amendments themselves, and the photographs of the fire and the factory floor.
- UDL — a present-day hook, plain-language summaries, cited images, and a choice of ways to respond.
- The civic cycle — watch a printed exposé or a factory fire turn into an actual federal law.
- The Arc of the Union — plot the era's climbs and setbacks on the trajectory you're building all year.

Flight crew this unit:

Archive (J. Troop)

Spark

Navigator

Notetaker

Who you'll travel with in this unit



Rosa, 17
Lower East Side, New
York City



Frankie, 16
New York City



Anna, 17
A wheat farm on the
Great Plains



Ada, 16
Fisk University,
Nashville, Tennessee



May, 17
Nashville, Tennessee

Spread 1 · US.08, US.09

Analyze Social Darwinism as a justification for inequality, and compare Washington's and Du Bois's strategies for Black advancement.

🔊 Somebody tells you the rich are rich because they're simply better — stronger, smarter, more deserving — and the poor earned their poverty by being weak. Then they slap the word 'science' on it and call it 'survival of the fittest.' It's 1900, and that idea is basically running the country. Now watch two Black leaders look at that same country and land on opposite plans for how to beat it.

The C-130 sets down at Fisk University in Nashville. Archive gathers the crew on the green. 'Ideas aren't just talk,' she says. 'The wrong one builds a cage. The right one picks the lock. Today you're going to hear three people argue about which idea wins.'



ERA-FRIEND

Ada · a student at Fisk, Nashville

Ada studies at Fisk, in the same halls where a young scholar named W. E. B. Du Bois earned his first degree years before her. Du Bois's argument hits her like oxygen: demand full civil and political rights now, not someday. Educate a 'talented tenth' of leaders. Protest injustice out loud, and never accept segregation as the price of survival. To Ada, patience is just injustice wearing better manners — and she is done being told to wait.

PRIMARY VOICE

Booker T. Washington · in his own case

Booker T. Washington would tell Ada he wants the very same destination — by a road he thinks won't get people killed. Born enslaved, he built Tuskegee to teach trades and self-reliance, and in his 1895 Atlanta speech he urged Black Southerners to 'cast down your bucket where you are': build economic strength first, and trust that full political rights follow once white America can't do without Black skill and labor. To his critics it sounded like surrender. To his followers it was survival in a South ruled by the rope. Hear his reasoning before you grade it.

INSTITUTION

The era's loudest idea · Social Darwinism

Hovering over the whole argument is the era's most convenient idea. Social Darwinism took Darwin's biology, twisted it, and used 'survival of the fittest' to argue that the rich deserved their power, the poor deserved their poverty, and the government should stay out of it. It handed the powerful a permission slip. Not everyone bought it: the Social Gospel movement fired back that Christians were called to fix slums, not bless them. But in 1900, the permission slip was winning — which is exactly why Ada's and Washington's fight mattered so much.

 **Primary source:** In 'The Souls of Black Folk' (1903), Du Bois wrote of the 'double-consciousness' of being both Black and American, and openly criticized Washington's willingness to accept segregation in exchange for economic progress.

 Both men were brilliant, brave, and right about some things. Instead of picking a 'winner,' ask: what did each strategy risk, and what did each one protect?

In plain words: Around 1900, many people used a twisted idea called Social Darwinism to say the rich deserved everything and the poor deserved nothing. Two Black leaders fought back in different ways. Booker T. Washington said: build money and skills first, accept segregation for now. W. E. B. Du Bois said: demand full rights and the vote right now, and protest. Both wanted freedom; they disagreed on how to get it.

 **Tennessee:** This argument runs straight through Tennessee. Fisk University in Nashville — founded in 1866 to educate freedpeople — is where W. E. B. Du Bois earned his first degree in 1888. The school that rose out of Reconstruction produced one of the sharpest voices demanding that Black Americans get their rights now, not later.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Jim Crow stripped Black Americans of rights while Social Darwinism told the country the inequality was natural.
- **Head out of the sand:** Black educators, students, and writers like Du Bois — and the institutions, like Fisk, that trained them.
- **Voice raised:** Higher education, the press, and organized protest (Du Bois helped found the Niagara Movement and, in 1909, the NAACP).
- **Government response:** Almost none yet — the federal fix would not come until the civil-rights era, generations later.
- **Still unfinished:** The strategy debate — patience vs. protest — echoes in every movement since.

✓ **Check:** Washington and Du Bois wanted the same goal but chose opposite strategies. Explain each strategy in one sentence, then argue which one you think fit the dangers of 1900 better — using evidence.

Show what you know:

- Write the letter Ada might send Booker T. Washington after his Atlanta speech.
 - Make a two-column chart of each leader's strategy, risks, and payoffs, then mark where you land.
 - Record a 60-second 'both were brave' explainer that refuses to pick a simple winner.
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Spread 2 • US.10, US.11

Explain how farmers (Granger/Populist) and workers (labor unions) organized to fight railroads and industry — and what it cost them.

💡 One company sets the price, and you have no choice but to pay it — sound familiar? For Anna's family, that company was the railroad, and the price was whatever it took to ship their wheat. For Rosa, it was the factory, and the price was her body. Neither of them could win alone. So they did the one thing that scares the powerful: they teamed up.

Archive splits the mission. She drops half the crew on Anna's wheat farm and half outside a steel mill, then patches them together over the radio. 'Two people, two thousand miles apart, figuring out the same trick at the same time,' she says. 'Watch what happens when regular people stop being alone.'



ERA-FRIEND

Anna • the freight bill that ate the farm

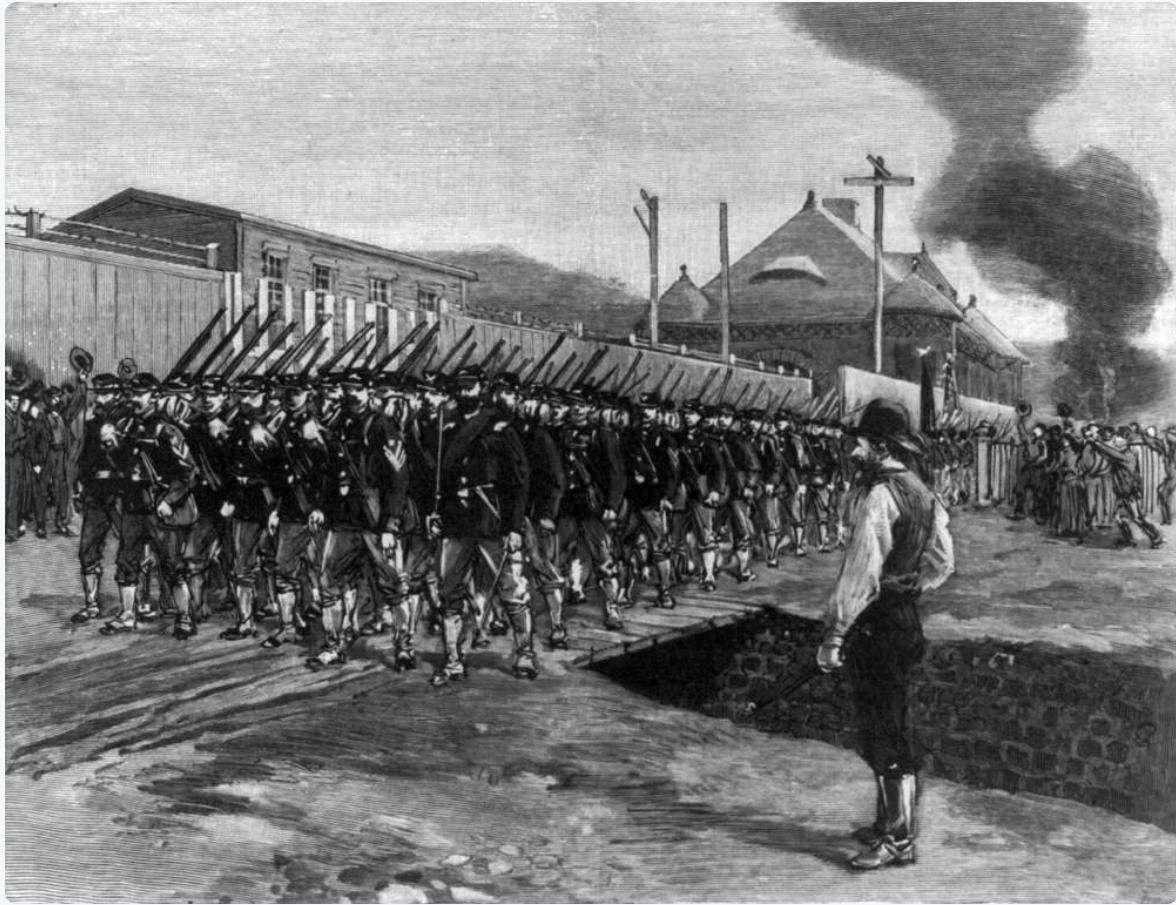
Anna's family grows the wheat, breaks their backs on it — and then the railroad charges whatever it wants to carry it to market, and the profit vanishes into a freight bill. One farm can't argue with a railroad. But thousands of farms can. Anna watches her parents join the Grange, then the Populists — farmers pooling their crops, building cooperatives, and pressuring states to pass 'Granger Laws' that cap what railroads can charge. It's the first time Anna sees ordinary people write a rule that a giant company has to obey.



ERA-FRIEND

Rosa • the union or nothing

Rosa has learned the factory's math: alone, you take whatever wage you're handed, because there are ten more workers behind you. Together, you can stop the machines. So she and her shopmates organize — a union, using strikes and collective bargaining and boycotts to demand better pay, shorter hours, and doors that aren't locked. It is terrifying and it is powerful. But Rosa also learns the cost: when steelworkers struck at Homestead in 1892, the company brought in armed guards, and the strike ended in blood and defeat. Standing together is strong. It is not safe.



📷 This 1892 stereograph collection documents the Homestead Steel Strike at Andrew Carnegie's mills, showing the Pinkerton battlefield, strikers guarding against scabs, and arriving state militia, highlighting violent labor conflict during industrialization. (US.11)

Underwood & Underwood, *The Homestead strike, 1892*, 1892. 8 photographic prints on stereo cards: stereograph. LOT 7105 (S) [P&P]. Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division.

<https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/2005684354/>.

💡 This is the aftermath at Homestead, 1892 — armed strikers, smoke, a company that won. Ask: if organizing was this dangerous and could still lose, why did workers keep doing it?

In plain words: One farm can't argue with a railroad, and one worker can't argue with a factory. So farmers and workers teamed up. Farmers formed the Grange and the Populist movement and won laws to limit railroad prices. Workers formed unions and used strikes to demand better pay and safety. Teaming up gave regular people power — but it was dangerous, and they didn't always win (the 1892 Homestead strike was crushed).

🟡 **Tennessee:** Tennessee farmers fought the same fight: they organized in the Farmers' Alliance against high railroad rates, and East Tennessee's coal miners had already gone to war — literally — against the convict-lease system in the Coal Creek uprising of the early 1890s. Organizing wasn't a Northern thing. It was happening in Tennessee's fields and coalfields too.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Railroads and factories held all the power over prices, wages, and safety.
- **Head out of the sand:** Farmers losing their profits and workers losing their health — and sometimes their lives.
- **Voice raised:** Cooperatives and lobbying (the Grange/Populists) and strikes and unions (labor).
- **Government response:** States passed Granger Laws regulating railroads (upheld in *Munn v. Illinois*, 1877); labor's biggest wins came slowly and unevenly, and strikes like Homestead were crushed first.
- **Still unfinished:** The balance of power between workers and employers is still argued today.

✓ **Check:** Farmers and industrial workers used different tactics but shared one core idea. Name the shared idea, then give one tactic each group used and one risk each faced.

Show what you know:

- Write two diary entries — Anna after a Grange meeting, Rosa after a strike vote.
 - Draw a simple 'strength in numbers' diagram for a farmer and for a factory worker.
 - Debate: which had the harder fight in 1892, organized farmers or organized workers? Use evidence.
-

Spread 3 · US.12, US.16, US.17

Analyze how trusts concentrated power, and how Roosevelt's Square Deal and Wilson's New Freedom used government to check it.

💡 Imagine one company owns the app, the phone, the store, and the road to the store — so there's nowhere else to go and no price but theirs. That was Standard Oil, and it wasn't an app; it was the oil that ran the country. For years nobody could touch it. Then a journalist with a notebook, and two presidents with a pen, decided to try.

Archive lands the crew in a newspaper office stacked with documents. Spark drops a thick magazine serial on the desk. 'One woman spent years reading this company's own paperwork,' he says, 'and turned it into the story that made America want its government back.'



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie · the notebook beats the tentacle

Frankie's been selling papers about the trusts for years; now he's reading them like a student. He learns that corporations had merged into 'trusts' — giant combinations that swallowed competitors, set prices, and squeezed workers, with Standard Oil the biggest of them all. What amazes Frankie isn't the octopus. It's the woman who beat it with paperwork: Ida Tarbell spent years digging through Standard Oil's own records and published the exposé that turned public fury into political will. To Frankie, that's the whole lesson — a notebook, used right, is a weapon.

INSTITUTION

Two presidents · the government answers

Then the government, for once, answered. Theodore Roosevelt made 'trust-busting' his brand — using the Sherman Antitrust Act to break harmful monopolies — and his Square Deal added consumer protections like the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act, plus a push to conserve wild land. Woodrow Wilson went further with his New Freedom: the Clayton Antitrust Act to put teeth in the law, the Federal Trade Commission to police business, and the Federal Reserve to steady the banks. Two very different presidents reached the same conclusion — a market this powerful needs a referee.

📄 **Primary source:** Ida Tarbell's 'The History of the Standard Oil Company' (1904) ran for months in McClure's Magazine, built entirely from the company's own records and court testimony.

💡 Tarbell didn't march or vote her way to change — she reported it. What makes a carefully documented story powerful enough to move a government?

In plain words: Some companies grew into 'trusts' — giant combinations that killed competition and set whatever prices they wanted. Standard Oil was the biggest. A journalist named Ida Tarbell exposed it. Then two presidents used the government to fight back: Theodore Roosevelt broke up trusts and passed food-safety laws, and Woodrow Wilson added the Clayton Act, the FTC, and the Federal Reserve. The message: a market that powerful needs rules.

🟡 **Tennessee:** Tennessee had been fighting concentrated railroad and industrial power since the Granger and Farmers' Alliance days, and Tennessee consumers and merchants felt the reach of national trusts in the prices they paid. When federal trust-busting and new agencies like the FTC arrived, they were answering a frustration Tennesseans had voiced for decades.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Trusts like Standard Oil concentrated enormous, unchecked economic and political power.
- **Head out of the sand:** Consumers, small businesses, and a public stirred by muckraking journalism.
- **Voice raised:** Investigative journalism (Tarbell) and public pressure and voting.
- **Government response:** Roosevelt's trust-busting and consumer laws (1906) and Wilson's Clayton Act, FTC, and Federal Reserve (1913–1914).
- **Still unfinished:** How big is too big, and how hard to enforce antitrust, are still open fights.

✓ **Check:** Trace one path from problem to fix: start with the power of the trusts, and explain how journalism and government together checked it. Name at least one muckraker and one law or agency.

Show what you know:

- Write the headline and lede Tarbell might use to open her Standard Oil series.
 - Make a flowchart: trust → exposé → public pressure → law/agency.
 - Debate: did the journalist or the presidents deserve more credit for checking the trusts?
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Spread 4 • US.13

Analyze industrial working conditions — child labor, sweatshops, and the Triangle fire — and the reforms they provoked.

🔔 146 people went to work one morning and never came home — most of them girls not much older than you, some younger. The factory doors were locked from the outside so nobody could sneak a break, and when the fire started, they couldn't get out. That was March 25, 1911. The country had looked away from the sweatshops for years. It could not look away from this.

Archive brings the crew down onto a crowded Manhattan street in front of a smoking building. She doesn't narrate this one. She just lets them look. 'Rosa sews in a shop just like this one,' she says quietly. 'Frankie could be any of the kids on this block. Watch what a country does after it finally sees.'



ERA-FRIEND

Rosa • it could have been her shop

Rosa makes shirtwaists — the exact garment sewn at the Triangle factory — and when the news breaks, her hands go cold, because she knows it could have been her building. She knows the locked doors, the crowded floors, the fire escape that was really just for show. For years the country treated the sweatshop as somebody else's problem. But 146 dead workers, most of them young immigrant women, laid out on the sidewalk, are impossible to file away. Rosa marches in the funeral procession, and for the first time she feels the city looking back.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • the kids in the picture

Frankie knows the other half of this story, because he's living it. He's a child laborer — up at six, hawking papers, no school. A photographer named Lewis Hine is going city to city making pictures of kids exactly like him: newsboys, mill kids, breaker boys, their faces aged past their years. Employers liked child workers because they were cheap and small enough to reach into machines. Frankie used to think nobody would care about a kid selling papers. Then he sees his own life in Hine's photographs — and realizes a picture can make a stranger care.



📷 This photograph captures the Asch Building during the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory fire on March 25, 1911, highlighting the dangers of industrial workplaces and sparking labor reforms in early 20th-century America (TN US.13).

Bain News Service, publisher. \"Scene of Washington Place fire.\" Photograph, March 1911. Library of Congress, Prints and Photographs Division, LC-B2- 2184-2 [P&P], LC-DIG-ggbain-09113.

<https://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/2014689101/>.

💡 This is the street outside the Triangle fire, March 1911 — the ladders that couldn't reach the top floors. Ask: the photograph shows the building, not the workers. Why might that make it easier — or harder — for the public to look?

MORE FROM THE RECORD



This 1908 photograph by Lewis Hine captures young newsboy John Howell on an Indianapolis street corner, starting work at 6 a.m., highlighting the grueling child labor conditions that fueled Progressive Era reforms in Tennessee US.13 standards.

In plain words: Factories, mines, and sweatshops made people, including women and children, work long hours in dangerous places. In 1911 a fire at the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory killed 146 workers, mostly young immigrant women, partly because the doors were locked. The country was horrified. That tragedy — and photographs of child workers by Lewis Hine — pushed lawmakers to pass new safety and child-labor laws.

● **Tennessee:** Tennessee wasn't watching from the outside. Children worked in Tennessee's cotton mills and industries too, and Progressive reformers pushed the state to pass child-labor restrictions in the early 1900s. The faces in Lewis Hine's photographs had cousins in Tennessee mill towns.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Unregulated factories and sweatshops put workers — especially women and children — in danger for cheap labor.
- **Head out of the sand:** Workers like Rosa, and a public forced to see the Triangle dead and Hine's child-labor photographs.
- **Voice raised:** Protest and mourning (the funeral marches), union organizing, and documentary photography.
- **Government response:** New York's Factory Investigating Commission passed sweeping workplace-safety laws (1911-1914); states and later the nation moved toward child-labor limits.
- **Still unfinished:** Worker safety and the line on child labor are still enforced and argued today.

✓ **Check:** The Triangle fire is often called a turning point. Explain what conditions caused so many deaths, and how the tragedy changed what the government required of factories.

Show what you know:

- Write the caption Lewis Hine might attach to a photo of Frankie to make a stranger care.
 - Create a 'before and after' list: factory rules before the Triangle fire, and after.
 - Record a respectful 60-second memorial that states the facts without sensationalizing them.
-

Spread 5 • US.14

Explain how muckrakers exposed abuses and mobilized public support for reform.

 You post a video of something wrong — a scam, a cover-up — and by morning it's everywhere and somebody powerful has to answer for it. That instinct that a hidden truth, once shown, can force change? It has a name that's over a century old: muckraking. In 1906 a young writer aimed it at your dinner, and Congress moved in months.

Archive drops the crew into the roar of a printing press. 'Frankie's spent his whole life selling other people's stories,' she says. 'Today he learns how to write one that bites.' Spark hands Frankie a brand-new novel that's about to ruin America's appetite.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie • from selling news to making it

Frankie has sold a thousand front pages; now he wants to write one. He's studying the muckrakers — journalists who dig up corruption and abuse and drag them into daylight. He reads Upton Sinclair's 'The Jungle,' a novel about the meatpacking plants so stomach-turning that readers stopped buying sausage — and started demanding laws. Within months, Congress passed the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act. Frankie does the math: Sinclair didn't hold office, didn't lead an army. He wrote what was true and made it impossible to ignore. That's the job Frankie wants.

PRIMARY VOICE

Upton Sinclair • the aim and the miss

Sinclair would tell Frankie the truth is more bitter than the win. He wrote 'The Jungle' to make America care about the immigrant workers ground up in the meatpacking plants — the human beings, not the meat. Instead, readers recoiled at what was in their food and demanded clean sausage. 'I aimed at the public's heart,' he said, 'and by accident I hit it in the stomach.' The food-safety laws were real and good. But Sinclair learned a hard lesson about voice: you can start a fire and still not get the blaze you were aiming for.

 **Primary source:** Upton Sinclair's 'The Jungle' (1906) followed an immigrant family destroyed by the meatpacking industry; its descriptions of filthy processing horrified readers.

💡 Sinclair wanted labor reform and got food-safety reform instead. What does that tell you about who controls what a piece of writing actually changes?

In plain words: Muckrakers were journalists who exposed hidden corruption and abuse to force reform. Upton Sinclair wrote 'The Jungle,' a novel about the disgusting meatpacking industry. It horrified readers so much that Congress quickly passed the Pure Food and Drug Act and Meat Inspection Act in 1906. Sinclair actually wanted to help the workers, but the public focused on their food instead — a reminder that a writer can't fully control what their story changes.

🟡 **Tennessee:** The muckraking instinct had deep Tennessee roots. Decades earlier, Ida B. Wells had built exactly this kind of evidence-driven journalism in Memphis, exposing lynching when almost no one else would. And muckrakers of the 1900s helped shine a light on child labor in Tennessee's own mills. Telling the hidden truth to force change was a Tennessee tradition before it had a national name.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Dangerous, filthy, and corrupt practices in industry were hidden from the public.
- **Head out of the sand:** Readers who suddenly saw what was in their food — and in the factories.
- **Voice raised:** Muckraking journalism (Sinclair's 'The Jungle,' and the wider muckraker movement).
- **Government response:** Congress passed the Pure Food and Drug Act and the Meat Inspection Act in 1906.
- **Still unfinished:** Sinclair's real target — worker exploitation — went largely unaddressed; the fight over journalism's power to force change continues.

✓ **Check:** Explain how a single book led to a federal law in 1906 — and why Sinclair considered the result a partial failure.

Show what you know:

- Write a modern 'muckraker' post exposing a problem you actually see — with evidence, not rumor.
 - Diagram the chain: book → public reaction → law, and mark where Sinclair's aim missed.
 - Debate: is a story that changes the 'wrong' thing still a success?
-

Spread 6 · US.15

Analyze Progressive democratic reforms that expanded citizen control (initiative, referendum, recall, direct primaries, 16th & 17th Amendments).

💡 What if you could skip the middleman and vote directly on the rule itself — no crooked politician required? That's not a fantasy app. It's what Progressives actually built a century ago, when they got sick of political machines choosing everything for them. They rewired American democracy so the people could grab the wheel.

Archive lands the crew at a statehouse on a voting day. 'Anna's family spent years pressuring politicians who didn't listen,' she says. 'Now watch the Progressives change the rules of the game itself — so the people can go around the politicians entirely.'



ERA-FRIEND

Anna · grabbing the wheel

Anna's family learned the hard way that a corrupt legislature can just ignore farmers. So the reforms of these years feel like a door opening. The initiative and referendum let citizens propose and vote on laws directly. The recall lets voters fire an official who betrays them. Direct primaries weaken the machines that used to pick candidates in back rooms. And in 1913, the 17th Amendment finally lets the people — not state legislatures — elect their own U.S. senators. To Anna, it all adds up to one idea: the people are done asking permission to be heard.



ERA-FRIEND

Frankie · the machine loses a grip

Frankie grew up watching the city machine trade favors for votes and hand-pick every candidate. So he notices what these reforms actually do: they pry the machine's fingers off the controls, one at a time. A direct primary means the bosses can't just anoint their guy. A recall means an official has to fear the voters, not just the party. Frankie is too street-smart to think corruption is over — machines adapt. But for the first time, he sees ordinary voters holding tools that used to belong only to the powerful.

📄 **Primary source:** The 17th Amendment (1913): 'The Senate of the United States shall be composed of two Senators from each State, elected by the people thereof...' — before it, state legislatures chose senators.

💡 One sentence moved the power to choose a senator from a few politicians to every voter. Why would Progressives see that as the whole ballgame?

In plain words: Progressives were tired of corrupt politicians and political machines making every decision. So they changed the rules of democracy to give people more direct control: the initiative and referendum (vote on laws directly), the recall (fire bad officials), and direct primaries (voters pick candidates). The 17th Amendment (1913) let people elect their own U.S. senators, and the 16th Amendment created the income tax. The goal: the people grab the wheel.

🟡 **Tennessee:** Tennessee lived this shift too: the state ratified the era's democratic amendments, and Tennessee's own Progressive reformers pushed against machine politics at home. The same frustration that drove Tennessee farmers into the Alliance drove the push to let voters, not bosses, make the calls.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** Political machines and state legislatures controlled who governed and which laws passed.
- **Head out of the sand:** Reformers and voters frustrated by corruption and being ignored.
- **Voice raised:** Organized reform movements, ballot campaigns, and constitutional amendment drives.
- **Government response:** States adopted the initiative, referendum, recall, and direct primaries; the 16th and 17th Amendments passed in 1913.
- **Still unfinished:** Money and organized power keep finding new ways into politics — the reform fight never fully ends.

✓ **Check:** Choose two Progressive democratic reforms and explain how each one shifted power away from political machines or state legislatures and toward ordinary citizens.

Show what you know:

- Write a one-paragraph pitch for the initiative and referendum to a skeptical voter.
 - Make a 'who chooses?' before-and-after chart for U.S. senators (pre- and post-17th Amendment).
 - Debate: did these reforms actually weaken corruption, or just change its shape?
-

Spread 7 • US.18

Analyze the women's suffrage movement and the ratification of the 19th Amendment — decided in Tennessee.

🔊 It comes down to one vote. One state left to make women's suffrage the law of the land, and that state is Tennessee. The count is tied. And the deciding ballot is in the hand of the youngest lawmaker in the room — a 24-year-old — with a letter from his mother folded in his pocket. Seventy years of marching, and it all balances on what one Tennessee kid does next.

Last stop. Archive sets the crew in the gallery of the Tennessee State Capitol, Nashville, August 18, 1920. The room is boiling. 'Every state that's going to ratify has ratified,' she says. 'It's 35 to go and Tennessee makes 36 — the 'Perfect 36.' Or it dies here. Watch history hold its breath.'



ERA-FRIEND

May • seventy years, one summer

May is seventeen, and she has grown up hearing that this fight is older than her grandmother. Women have marched, picketed, lobbied, gone to jail, and campaigned state by state for the right to vote — organizers like Carrie Chapman Catt running the national strategy and Nashville's own Anne Dallas Dudley leading the fight in Tennessee. Now it has all funneled down to May's home state on a blistering August day. She stands in the Capitol gallery, close enough to see the yellow roses the suffragists wear and the red ones the other side wears, and she understands: whatever happens in this room happens to her whole life.

PRIMARY VOICE

Harry & Febb Burn • 'be a good boy'

The vote deadlocks, 48 to 48. Then it reaches Harry Burn, twenty-four, the youngest man in the Tennessee legislature, wearing a red anti-suffrage rose. In his pocket is a letter from his mother, Febb, back home. 'Hurrah and vote for suffrage,' she wrote, 'don't keep them in doubt... be a good boy.' When his name is called, Harry Burn says 'aye.' The chamber erupts. Tennessee becomes the 36th state, and the 19th Amendment — 'the right of citizens... to vote shall not be denied... on account of sex' — becomes part of the Constitution. A mother's letter, a young man's nerve, and 26 million women can vote.

GROUP

The other roses · why some opposed it

Not everyone in that room wore yellow. Many Tennesseans — including some women — wore the red rose against ratification, and their reasons deserve honest hearing: some feared upending the household and Southern tradition, some worried about states' rights, and some white Southerners feared expanding the electorate in a Jim Crow state. It's worth noticing, too, that the 19th Amendment opened the ballot to women in principle, while Jim Crow laws still blocked many Black women from actually using it. The 'Perfect 36' was a real triumph — and, like most of this era, an unfinished one.

 **Primary source:** The 19th Amendment (1920): 'The right of citizens of the United States to vote shall not be denied or abridged by the United States or by any State on account of sex.'

 This sentence enfranchised tens of millions — yet Jim Crow kept many Black women from the polls for decades more. How can a victory be real and incomplete at the same time?

In plain words: For about 70 years, women fought for the right to vote using marches, protests, lobbying, and going to jail. By 1920, they needed one more state to make it law — and it came down to Tennessee. The vote was tied until 24-year-old Harry Burn voted yes, after his mother wrote him a letter telling him to support suffrage. Tennessee became the deciding 36th state, and the 19th Amendment gave women the vote — though Jim Crow still blocked many Black women.

 **Tennessee:** This one isn't a Tennessee connection — it's a Tennessee climax. The entire national suffrage movement came down to the Tennessee General Assembly in Nashville on August 18, 1920. Nashville's Anne Dallas Dudley helped lead the movement, and a 24-year-old East Tennessean named Harry Burn cast the deciding vote after his mother Febb wrote him to 'be a good boy' and support suffrage. American women got the vote on Tennessee's floor.

Toward a more perfect union — the cycle

- **Problem:** American women were denied the vote — half the country locked out of its own democracy.
- **Head out of the sand:** Generations of women organizers, from national leaders to Nashville's Anne Dallas Dudley.
- **Voice raised:** Decades of parades, picketing, lobbying, civil disobedience, and state-by-state campaigns.
- **Government response:** Congress passed and the states ratified the 19th Amendment, clinched by Tennessee on August 18, 1920.
- **Still unfinished:** Jim Crow still blocked many Black women; the fight to make the vote real for everyone continued for decades.

✓ **Check:** The 19th Amendment is a triumph and an unfinished one. Explain how women won the vote (including Tennessee's deciding role) AND why the victory was incomplete for many Black women.

Show what you know:

- Write the letter Febb Burn sends her son — or the reply Harry sends back afterward.
- Map the suffrage fight to its Tennessee finish line, marking Nashville and the 36-state count.
- Debate the red-rose position fairly, then rebut it with evidence — and name what the win left unfinished.

Toward a more perfect union

If Unit 1 was the country growing fast and leaving people behind, Unit 2 is the country arguing about what it owes the people it left. Watch closely: this is the era where Americans discover that a photograph, a strike, or a vote can force the government to act — and where they learn how slow, partial, and hard-won those fixes really are.

Closing question: Across this unit you saw at least five kinds of power try to fix a broken system: charity, protest, unions, journalism, and the law. Pick the two you think actually moved the country the most, cite evidence from the unit, and defend your ranking. There's no answer key — make the case.

This unit on the Arc of the Union

You decide: did each of these move the country **toward** its founding promise of liberty and equality for all — or away from it? There's no answer key — mark your own read and defend it with evidence.

Year	Milestone	What happened	Your call
1892	Homestead Strike crushed	Carnegie Steel breaks a major strike with armed force; labor loses.	
1895	Atlanta Compromise (Washington)	Washington urges economic progress and temporary accommodation to segregation.	
1906	Pure Food & Drug and Meat Inspection Acts	Muckraking and public outrage produce the first federal food-safety laws.	
1911	Triangle Shirtwaist fire	146 workers die behind locked doors; the disaster forces safety reform.	
1913	17th Amendment (direct election of senators)	The people, not state legislatures, elect U.S. senators.	
1914	Clayton Act & Federal Trade Commission	Wilson's New Freedom puts teeth in antitrust and creates a business watchdog.	
1920	19th Amendment ratified in Tennessee	Tennessee's deciding vote makes women's suffrage the law of the land.	